of a release, there is one filmmaker who has refused to capitulate to the CBFC's demands, which resulted in her film not having a theatrical release in India. Sandhya Suri, whose India-set film *Santosh* was the UK's submission for best international film at the Oscars last year, felt the cuts demanded would hurt the film's narrative. "It was very important to me that the film release in India, so I did try to figure out if there was a way to make it work," she told *The Guardian*. "But, in the end, it was just too difficult to make those cuts and have a film that still made sense, let alone stayed true to its vision." *Santosh*'s leading lady Shahana Goswami told India Today Digital that the "list of changes" expected were ones that the makers were "not in agreement with".

SELECTIVE OUTRAGE

For some, the CBFC's actions reek of double standards. "India's censor board did not object to a single scene from propaganda movies like *The Kashmir Files* or *The Kerala Story*. But it was quick to object to films like *Phule*. It shows the mentality of the board," Jayant Patil, Maharashtra chief of NCP (SP), had said in response to the controversy. Mahadevan, too, feels it's not a level playing field and there are different rules for different filmmakers. While excessively violent films are handed 'A' certification without any cuts, films like *Phule* and *Santosh*, which showcase an inconvenient truth around caste, face a tough battle. "They should differentiate between the intent of the filmmakers—whether they are honest and truly representing, or trying to exaggerate and have an agenda," says Mahadevan. "Do we have people who have a mature outlook to make the decision?

Mahadevan's film finally released on April 25 but only after he fought the good fight and endured two screenings for the examining committee. Mahadevan says the board suggested he remove the scene where a Brahmin boy throws *gobar* (cowdung) at Savitribai, a scene that has been depicted in a 1950 Marathi film as well as in an episode of Shyam Benegal's classic series *Bharat Ek Khoj*. "They had okayed it in the beginning. Why are you getting cold feet because of a few Brahmins?" Worse, Mahadevan felt forced to clarify his intent by invoking his own Brahmin caste identity, something that went against the very grain of his intent behind *Phule*. "I had to make a stupid statement that I am a Brahmin and would not run down Brahmins," he says. "I was provoked to say I am one of you."



SANTOSH
Objecting to police brutality, caste discrimination and misogyny in the film, the CBFC asked for so many cuts that its filmmaker refused to release it in India



"I wanted the film to release in India, so I did try to see if there was a way to make it work. But, in the end, it was just too difficult to make those cuts and have a film that still made sense"

SANDHYA SURI, *Santosh* director, in an interview to *The Guardian*

In a more worrying trend, filmmakers themselves are opting for self-censorship even after a clean chit from the CBFC. This is what the makers of *L2: Empuraan* did two days after the film's release—deleted scenes indirectly signalling the atrocities committed on Muslims during the 2002 Gujarat riots—to mollify irate Hindutva outfits who accused the film of attempting to "malign Hinduism" and "appease anti-national elements". The name of the villain who incites a mob to riot in the film was also changed, because it was too similar to that of a real-life perpetrator.

"As an artist, it is my duty to ensure none of my films promote hatred toward any political movement, ideology or religious community," the film's leading man Mohanlal said in a post on Facebook.

Censorship is alive and kicking, in a board that's meant to certify. Mahadevan cites the example of the ratings handed out by the Motion Picture Association of America. These range from 'G', which is the most audience-friendly, and 'NC-17', which restricts audience below 17. Issuing cuts is not part of its job. "We have changed the name [of the board], giving everyone the impression that it's a certifying board, but we have not dropped the censorship," says Mahadevan. "It has defeated the purpose totally." INDIA TODAY reached out to the CBFC for a comment, but didn't get a response. Looking back on *Phule*'s journey, Mahadevan feels he may have done something right eventually. "They have taken *Phule* so seriously, they know where the danger lies, that it's meant to be a serious document and statement." ■